

Nationalist Conspiracy: Review of Enis Sulstarova's *Samiu dhe Utopia*

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Abstract: *Enis Sulstarova, Samiu dhe Utopia (Tirana: Pika pa sipërfaqe, 2024)*

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Many Albanians have taken to the streets beneath a bewildering array of banners. Their colours include the rainbow of the LGBT community, the red and black of the nationalists, green for the environmentalists, pink for the flamingo and its attendant bird-watchers, and white for clean underwear. Some of these colours merely unsettle; others openly polarise.

Other protesters carry neither flags nor banners but, according to Albania's prime minister, Edi Rama, Iranian or Russian money in their pockets. Rama describes a grand conspiracy in which some demonstrators are paid, some are propelled by the opposition, others are misled by foreign propaganda, and still others are merely swept up in the attention economy of social media and influencers. Perhaps there is a conspiracy: an attempt to overthrow Rama or destabilise Albania. Russia and Iran would certainly benefit from such disorder, as might Serbia, Greece, or, for that matter, certain Albanians themselves.

The intellectuals among the protesters likewise suspect their opponents of conspiring to fracture, infiltrate, and ultimately compromise the movement from within. On the right, conspiracy theorists like Altin Gonxhaj interpret the rainbow and flamingo-pink banners as evidence of a Soros Foundation scheme to undermine the protest and control its political outcome.¹² On the left, conspiracy theorists believe that the ghost of fascism has returned to Albania. Until now, this spectre had survived quietly in memories and books, waiting in the dark for the present to summon it back to life. It reveals itself, they argue, in the uncivilised screams, aggressive behaviour, and unkempt beards of angry, confused, and sexually frustrated young men.¹³

Albanian fascism flickered into view during the Italian occupation, continued to breathe beneath national communism, and was nearly buried in the marginal, self-published nationalist newspapers of the 1990s. Now, amid the ongoing protests, it is once again churning like a whirlpool beneath the waves of mobilisation, according to Gresa Hasa, a PhD researcher at the University of Vienna.¹⁴ Hasa further argues that Albanian fascism was always present but has recently become more visible through the return of the diaspora and the reawakening of an older nationalist repertoire. She identifies a diffuse and volatile constellation of individuals and small networks combining ultranation-

¹²Shpend Gashi, 'Strategjia e Protestes,' podcast, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1Vo0fpEyEgQ>.

¹³Ervin Qafemolla, 'Antisorosistët e protestës,' *Peizazhe të fjalës*, 2026, <https://peizazhe.com/2026/08/30/antisorosistet-e-protestes/>.

¹⁴Gresa Hasa, LinkedIn, <https://www.linkedin.com/feed/update/urn:li:activity:7498423171436605440/>.

alist rhetoric and sympathy for fascist ideas with intimidation, aggression, and attempts to silence or discredit protesters.

These symmetrical suspicions fit neatly within the conceptual scheme proposed by Robert Weisal in his seminal work on Albanian conspiracy theories. Weisal analyses what he calls ‘epistemic conspiracies,’ alongside the imperialist ‘conspiratorial epistemic community’ and the healthier category of the ‘conspiratorial epistemic.’¹⁵ An ‘epistemic conspiracy’ consists of scientific knowledge produced or imposed by Western epistemic communities upon their colonial subjects, or subsequently embraced by those subjects themselves, with *Orientalism* as its paradigmatic example. Right- and left-wing Albanian intellectuals alike search for a theoretical coherence capable of disciplining their empirical material. In doing so, they expose themselves to the divisive theoretical injections from imperial centres and to the memes through which those theories circulate. The Russian-Ukrainian war and Israeli-American colonial enterprises have, however, produced a crisis within the ‘epistemic conspiracy,’ and the ideologies they feed. This crisis is now reproduced within Albania’s own epistemic community.

Was this the kind of conspiracy that Sami Frashëri sought to combat with a counter-conspiracy of his own? In the aftermath of Serbian and Greek independence from the Ottoman Empire, Sami came to see the creation of an Albanian state as both a defence against external designs and an act of political invention. As neighbouring states sought to divide Albanian-speaking territories among themselves, they also divided Albanians against themselves.

This historical counter-conspiracy is the subject of Enis Sulstarova’s recent study. A professor at the University of Tirana, Sulstarova reads the project set out in Sami Frashëri’s *What Albania Was, What It Is, and What It Will Become* as both a master plan and a utopia: an alternative society organised around a moral principle and the political architecture of a new state.

At the centre of this utopian blueprint lies a concrete political programme. It seeks to create an Albanian political subject, unite it, and secure its survival in a hostile world. The nation-state thus appears simultaneously as an instrument, a shield against conspiracy, and an end in itself.

This is where the project’s conspiratorial character becomes visible. History appears as a closed circle of forces that divide, impoverish, and threaten Albanians, while the solution requires an organised collective bound by *besa* and a state apparatus capable of overturning the plot.

The enemy may change its name: empire, local elites, federalism, foreign influence, or any universal project that weakens national belonging. It may even speak Albanian, Russian, or Esperanto. The formula remains the same: danger comes simultaneously from outside and within, while salvation resides in political unity.

Sulstarova understands that this project does not belong exclusively to the nineteenth century. He therefore defends a programmatic reading of Sami’s text against a dystopian one, asking that the manifesto serve as both a critical mirror and a guide to the future in an age of depopulation, economic crisis, and global insecurity. At this point, the historian of ideas becomes a political

¹⁵Robert Weisal, “Introduction,” in *Albanian Conspiracy Theories* (2026), 10–65.

intermediary: rather than consigning the utopia to the history books, he revives its conspiratorial energy.

There have even been suggestions that Sami Frashëri was a Freemason or a member of the Illuminati, accusations also levelled at Ismail Qemali and some of the Young Turks.¹⁶ The speculation is not entirely implausible—at least if one accepts the alleged continuity between the Rilindja and the communist movement: a hidden political current passing through successive historical forms.¹⁷

Yet such a conspiratorial interpretation has its limits. Sulstarova reconstructs the intellectual biography of a thinker with wide-ranging philosophical interests, firm religious convictions, and political commitments that resist easy classification. Sami Frashëri emerges as an enlightened Muslim who distinguished political ends from the instruments used to pursue them. He adopted Western forms of organisation and mobilisation, together with selected ideas and political programmes, while retaining a critical distance from both Ottoman-Turkish and Western orthodoxies.¹⁸ Elvis Hoxha's afterword extends the same logic into the present. Historical circumstances cannot simply be accepted as given; they must be transformed through collective will, expressed through knowledge, organisation, and political action.

In Sulstarova's book, then, Sami emerges as the author of a plan that is still operating behind the scenes. Sulstarova reawakens this conspiracy, translates it into contemporary terms, and adapts it to the present crisis. As colonial and imperial wars continue to structure an uncertain world—from the interventions of the United States and Russia to conflicts among states across the Middle East—the nation-state once again presents itself as the most natural answer. Sami's utopia can therefore return as a conspiratorial solution and not merely a relic of the past.

Alongside his political project, Sulstarova quietly smuggles a pedagogical method into a book intended for a general readership. In the German tradition of civic education, this method is known as the *Zukunftswerkstatt*, or Future Workshop.¹⁹

The Future Workshop belongs to the family of future-oriented learning methods. It proceeds from the assumption that people possess often untapped creative capacities and problem-solving abilities that can be activated. The method seeks to release these resources so that participants can develop individual or shared visions of the future and identify concrete steps towards realising them.

A Future Workshop generally proceeds through three phases: a critique phase, in which the existing situation is analysed; a utopian phase, in which a desirable future is imagined; and a realisation phase, in which that vision

¹⁶T. S. Nefes, 'The Function of Secrecy in Anti-Semitic Conspiracy Theories: The Case of Dönmes in Turkey,' in *Conspiracy Theories in the United States and the Middle East: A Comparative Approach* (2014), 139–156.

¹⁷Mustafa Mustafai, 'Jewish Conspiracies in Albania,' in Robert Weisal, *Conspiracy Theories in Albania* (2026).

¹⁸Enis Sulstarova, *Arratisje nga Lindja: Orientalizmi shqiptar nga Naimi te Kadareja* (Globic Press, 2006).

¹⁹Robert Jungk and Norbert R. Müller, *Zukunftswerkstätten: Mit Phantasie gegen Routine und Resignation* (München, 1981).

is translated into practical courses of action. Its defining purpose is therefore not merely to produce positive visions of the future, but to discover ways of initiating and sustaining the changes needed to bring them about.

Sulstarova invites his readers to undertake precisely such a thought experiment. Read in this way, Sami's work itself becomes a Future Workshop: it diagnoses an unsatisfactory present, imagines a desirable national future, and proposes the political means through which that future might be realised. This is perhaps Sulstarova's most modern—and most conspiratorial—interpretive move. Sami's text supplies not only the blueprint for a new society but also the pedagogical mechanism through which popular support for that blueprint can be mobilised.